

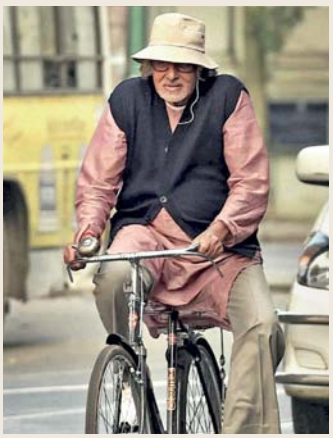
By JUHI CHATURVEDI

"They lie who say they don't want to be like him"

Mr Bachchan is a hermit...a monk. His destinations are his characters. He travels and lives those parts just the way we live in our homes...safe, with a deep sense of belonging. And yet he doesn't remain in that place. He is constantly, film after film, character after character, seeking salvation, seeking the truth...the intense (*Shoebite*), the profound (*Pink*), luminous (***Piku***, right), hilarious (*Gulabo Sitabo*) truth that dissolves his previous identity and frees him even further.

He seems like a man who has renounced all that he owns, left only with his art. Bhashkor Banerjee is not a project he has signed on for motivation or work; he doesn't need that after a glorious cinema-defining journey. What he is doing perhaps is to find an entirely new understanding of himself, of the world he is a part of and so intensely that he can give up, leave behind, detach from that Bachchan forever.

When he plays Chunnan Mirza (*Gulabo Sitabo*), he is perhaps letting out his inner offender that we all have but keep hidden...he is letting it out because he does not want it to come in the way of his journey. His method, his rehearsing lines, his discipline...we



all know it. What we don't realise is that every time he does that, he leaves behind a lesson for all of us. They are all lying who say they don't want to be like him.

The Bachchan universe has no pretensions, no worry or hurry to acquire more. It is instead a reference for the generations to come, a ready reckoner on how to be an artist. It is a colourful LEGO set you can build your careers with. All directors, writers, technicians have used it.

He built whatever he had to... name, fame, wealth, whatever we understand as a successful career, long back. Now, he's making sense of his birth, a blessed one. ■

***Juhi Chaturvedi is the writer of* Piku *and* Gulabo Sitabo**

PVR cinemas in an FHF retrospective called *Bachchan: Back to the Beginning*. If there's one living actor who merits a retrospective, it is of course Bachchan. With tickets priced at Rs 80, Dungarpur says most shows are sold out—and even actors are calling seeking tickets for *Amar Akbar Anthony*. "There's nobody who bridges the past, present and future of Indian cinema better than Mr Bachchan," says Dungarpur, whose foundation is entrusted with the Bachchan archive. "He has preserved the past and continues to preserve the present, as evident by his numbered tweets. Most people exist and allow things to happen [to them], but he is aware of the world he lives in." He writes his own tweets and blog entries. Beyond technology, Bachchan has kept up with the times sartorially too, carrying off hoodies and sweatpants or blingy brooches with elan. He recently even introduced a new line of perfumes.

But since 1999, his focus has been acting. Having learned from the ABCL debacle, AB Corp has stuck to co-producing a few films. Next year, audiences will see three generations of Bachchans. His grandson, Agastya Nanda, makes his debut in Zoya Akhtar's Netflix film *The Archies*; son Abhishek will feature in Balki's *Ghoomer* and Amitabh, at the grand age of 80, has the multilingual *Project K* alongside Deepika Padukone and Prabhas.

In 1997, after his maiden home production *Mrityudaata* flopped, INDIA TODAY wrote, "The question is: where does Bachchan go from here?" Little did we, or anyone, know that 25 years later, we'd "still" be talking about him. His name means 'the light that won't fade'. Fittingly, thus, it illuminates darkened cinema halls, living room televisions and now our mobile screens. That's how long his reign has been. The answer to that question, though? Here it goes: Amitabh Bachchan is here to perform until his last breath. And the world is a better place for it. ■

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